

Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM



Terrance Owens, 10, picks out a backpack for the school year during the Beegrs8t Back-to-School Youth Kickoff on Aug. 6 in the Washington Heights neighborhood of Chicago. Kids received a free backpack, book and other school supplies. **DOMINIC DI PALERMO/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Supplying basics, fun for students

CPS, communities host back-to-school events, drawing big crowds

By **Kate Perez**
and **William Tong**
Chicago Tribune

Christy Bolden shepherded her four kids around the Piotrowski Park field on a toasty August afternoon. The retired nurse browsed

booths offering school supplies, informational flyers and free food at a CPS “Back-to-School Bash.”

Tuesday’s event, one of four held around the city, helped Bolden defray the costs of school supplies for her children, who attend Smyth Elementary School on the Near West Side and CICS Bucktown, she said.

“Things have just skyrocketed in price: the paper, the pencils, disinfecting wipes, everything they

need,” Bolden said. “I don’t want them to go to school unprepared like some of the other kids.”

Bolden and her kids are among the many Chicago families who flocked to back-to-school events in late July and early August that provided free supplies at a time when parents across the U.S. report struggling to afford educational materials. Several local

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STATE FAIR GOP DAY



Audience members sing the national anthem during Republican Day at the Illinois State Fair on Thursday. **DOMINIC DI PALERMO/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Illinois Republicans rally around President Trump

Leaders hope for a ‘renaissance,’ but internal infighting continues

By **Rick Pearson**
and **Jeremy Gorner**
Chicago Tribune

SPRINGFIELD — Illinois Republicans used their day at the State Fair on Thursday to pledge their allegiance to President Donald Trump and the Trump-backed plan to redistrict Texas’ congressional boundaries to gain GOP seats that led to that state’s House Democrats fleeing to Illi-

nois to try to block it.

But as state GOP leaders sought to promote a Republican “renaissance” that could turn Illinois from a blue state to red based on the state’s 2024 presidential results that showed Trump getting 43.5% of the vote, serious problems remain for a political party still trying to elevate itself from the brink of irrelevance.

The Illinois GOP remains plagued by infighting that for

years has come at the expense of winning campaigns. The state Republicans have routinely witnessed battles between far-right insurgents who in recent years have complained the party isn’t Trumpy enough and the financial institutional wing that has long been the GOP establishment and funded the party for decades.

With the circulation of candidacy petitions well underway,

the party has yet to formally field a full slate of candidates against Democrats who hold all statewide offices. Some candidates running for governor to challenge two-term billionaire Gov. JB Pritzker or seeking other statewide offices lack big-name status or credibility to mount a serious campaign.

Big money Republicans who

Turn to Fair, Page 2

Putin praises Trump’s efforts

Kyiv, Europe worry summit in Alaska will favor Moscow

By **Pan Pylas**
and **Justin Spike**
Associated Press

LONDON — Russian President Vladimir Putin on Thursday praised President Donald Trump’s efforts to end the war in Ukraine, more than three years after Moscow launched its invasion, as the two leaders prepared for a pivotal summit between the U.S. and Russia Friday in Alaska.

Following a meeting Thursday with top government officials on the summit, Putin said in a short video released by the Kremlin that the Trump administration was making “quite energetic and sincere efforts to stop the hostilities” and to “reach agreements that are of interest to all parties involved.”

Putin also suggested that “long-term conditions of peace between our countries, and in Europe, and in the world as a whole,” could be reached under an agreement with the U.S. on nuclear arms control.

In Washington, Trump said there was a 25% chance that the summit would fail, but he also floated the idea that, if the meeting succeeds, he could bring Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy to Alaska for a subsequent, three-way meeting.

In a radio interview with Fox News, Trump also said he might be willing to stay in Alaska longer, depending on what happens with Putin.

Meanwhile, Zelenskyy and other European leaders worked to ensure their interests are taken into account when Trump and Putin meet in Anchorage.

U.K. Prime Minister Keir

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Texas Democrats plan departure

Texas House Democrats who fled to Illinois said they would return to Austin after lawmakers adjourn their current special session Friday and California Democrats introduce their retaliatory map designed to neutralize the Texas GOP effort. **Chicagoland, Page 3**

US law enforcement expands in DC

The Washington, D.C., police chief stepped up cooperation between her officers and federal immigration officials as President Donald Trump’s law enforcement takeover of the nation’s capital takes root. **Nation & World**

Burnett III hopes to outgrow shadow of father



Walter Redmond Burnett III sits inside The Hoxton in Chicago on Tuesday. **JOHN J. KIM/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

29-year-old seeks his dad’s City Council seat representing 27th Ward

By **Jake Sheridan**
Chicago Tribune

Walter Redmond Burnett III knows what you’re thinking.

The 29-year-old seeking a City Council seat is well prepared for the question lingering around his quest to lead the 27th Ward: Is it fair he be appointed to succeed his father? “I get it,” he said. But “Red” wants you to really look at him.

“I understand where people are coming from, but if you remove my name from the paper, I have an excellent resume,” he told the Tribune. “I would put my resume

up against just about anyone’s.”

He paused. “Probably except my dad’s.” Mayor Brandon Johnson must soon weigh the qualifications himself. The mayor has less than two months to make a pick after his vice mayor, Ald. Walter Burnett Jr., resigned in July. Burnett spent 30 years in the City Council and ended that career as one of Johnson’s most crucial allies — a twist from his endorsement of Johnson’s campaign runoff opponent.

The seat’s application window closes Friday. But before political jockeying could even begin, the older Burnett made sure all signs pointed down his family tree.

“I think the mayor will consider

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